

Paper 4, Option 4A: Buddhism

Topics	What students need to learn	
1 Religious beliefs, values and teachings	1.1	The Four Noble Truths as the basis of Buddhism and the centrality of such for different Buddhists a) The Three Poisons. b) the Buddha's teaching on suffering and the cessation of craving/desire in the Four Noble Truths: dukkha, samudaya/tanha, nirodha and magga. Including reference to the nature of Enlightenment and nibbana. c) The Eightfold Path: - o its summary in the Three-fold Way: ethics, meditation and wisdom - o the ethical principles of the Noble Eightfold Path: right action, right speech, right livelihood - o the qualities of metta, karuna and khanti - o the relationship between these principles and the Four Noble truths. How these are understood in Theravada and Mahayana, both historically and in the contemporary world. With reference to the ideas of D Keown and B Bodhi.
	1.2	How the three marks and the Five khandas are understood in Theravada and Mahayana, both historically and in the contemporary world, including how they may be linked to the rejection of the idea of the self and the non-existence of God. a) The three marks of existence and how these are reflected throughout existence and also through Buddhist teachings. The importance of this in understanding the nature of reality, the ultimate reality, and the meaning and purpose of life. b) The Five khandas in Theravada; death and the afterlife: the concept of rebirth, Nibbana, karma and the search for Enlightenment. The importance of this in understanding the nature of reality, the ultimate reality, and the meaning and purpose of life. With reference to the ideas of Buddhaghosa in the Visuddhimagga and T W Rinpoche.
	1.3	The meaning and significance of the three refuges: the Buddha, dhamma and the sangha a) The significance of each of these for a place of refuge within Buddhism. b) The interrelationship between these three refuges. c) Different interpretations of the role and nature of the sangha and the role and nature of the Buddha. d) The implications of the refuges for worship and daily life.

Topics	What students need to learn	
		How these are understood in Theravada and Mahayana, both historically and in the contemporary world. With reference to the ideas of B Bodhi and T Bhikkhu.
	1.4	Key Moral Principles a) The Five Precepts. b) How these are understood in Theravada and Mahayana both historically and in the contemporary world. With reference to the ideas of P Harvey and B Bodhi.
